

# Raising awareness of harassment against politicians

Experimental evidence on the democratic consequences from four European democracies  
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# Motivation

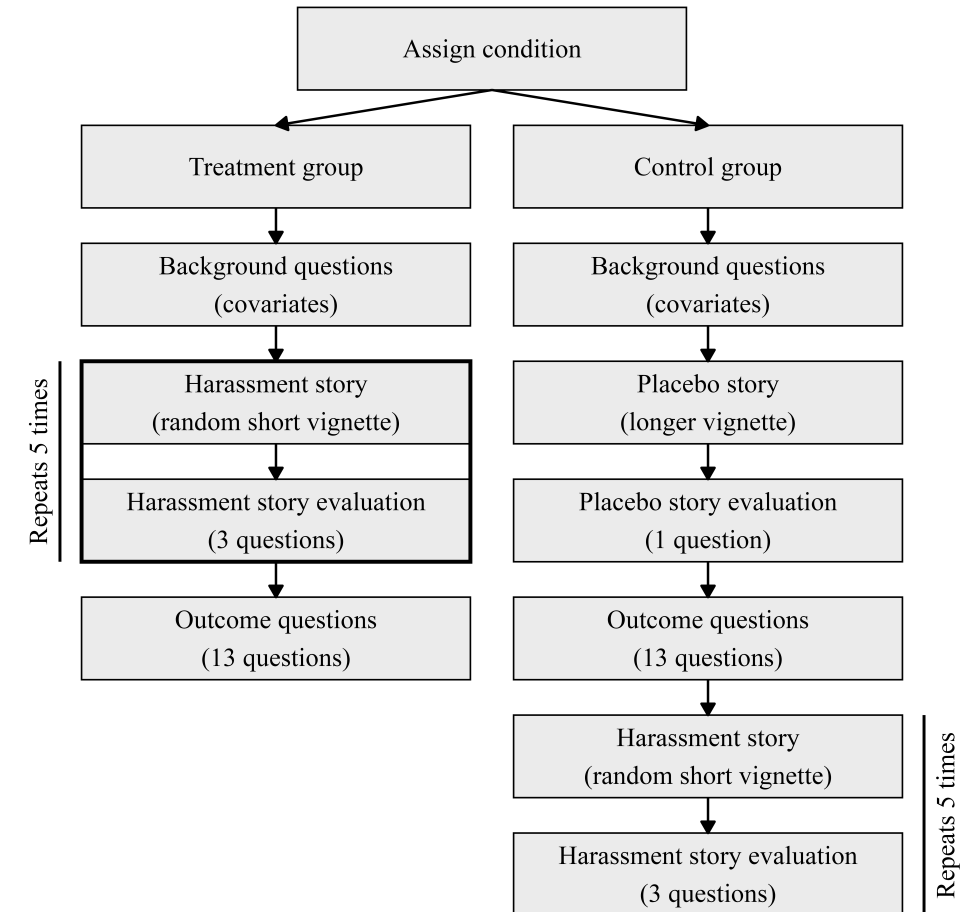
- Growing knowledge about **costs and risks of harassment** to politicians and candidates
  - also about implications in terms of stress, behavior, protection, exits
  - ultimately about democratic **representation**
  - **experimental (causal) evidence** is sparse, especially on *citizens*
- *RQ: How do **citizens** respond to **increased awareness** about harassment of politicians?*
- Preregistered **survey experiment**
  - large sample with **four European countries**
  - *treatments*: **true harassment stories**
  - *outcomes*: political (dis)**engagement and attitudes** on harassment and democracy
- Increasing awareness of harassment could have **bad implications**
  - if **citizens are deterred** from considering entering/engaging in politics
  - or if harassment awareness causes **cynicism, backlash, or apathy**

# Design

- New multinational preregistered **survey experiment**
- **n = 8,899**
  - Denmark: n = 5,008 (YouGov)
  - Germany: n = 1,519 (Prolific)
  - United Kingdom: n = 1,515
  - France: n = 857
- **Treatment**
  - **real stories** about (Danish) politicians' experiences with harassment
  - stimulus sampling design
  - read and evaluate **5 harassment stories**
    - random draw from 55 curated, paraphrased stories
  - **story evaluation**: *seriousness, justifiableness, harmfulness*

# Outcomes

1. Perceived **prevalence** and personal **risk**
2. Three attitudes towards **harassment** in politics
3. Satisfaction with **democracy**
4. Willingness to **run for office** in the future
5. **Index** of willingness to **engage** in six political activities



# Treatment: 5/55 harassment stories<sup>1</sup>

“I have experienced my election posters being ‘decapitated’ by unknown persons. My children, aged seven and nine, have seen this, which was very unpleasant.”

“I have experienced unpleasant advances in private messages on social media from people of all ages.”

“I have received death threats from unknown senders directed at both my little brothers and my own children.”

“There was a citizen who drove around in a car and measured how high my - and only my - posters were placed from the ground. He then reported me to the police for banners that were placed too low.”

# Treatment: example

1. 1 of 4 politician *gender-age* groups (randomized)

2. Story

3. Three evaluation questions

*Repeats 5 times...*

**YouGov**

Kvindelig politiker (over 35 år):

***"Efter valget havde jeg en ubehagelig oplevelse med et medlem fra et andet parti, som, uden mit samtykke, havde taget et billede af mig og lagt det op på Facebook..."***

(5 ud af 5)

Hvor alvorligt, synes du, det, politikerens fortæller om, er?

Slet ikke alvorligt  Meget alvorligt

☐ Ved ikke

Hvor enig eller uenig er du i, at det kan være i orden at sige eller gøre dette mod politikere under visse omstændigheder?

Helt uenig Delvist uenig Hverken enig eller uenig Delvist enig Helt enig

☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐

☐ Ved ikke

I hvilken grad ville det have påvirket dig selv negativt?

Slet ikke I lav grad I nogen grad I høj grad I meget høj grad

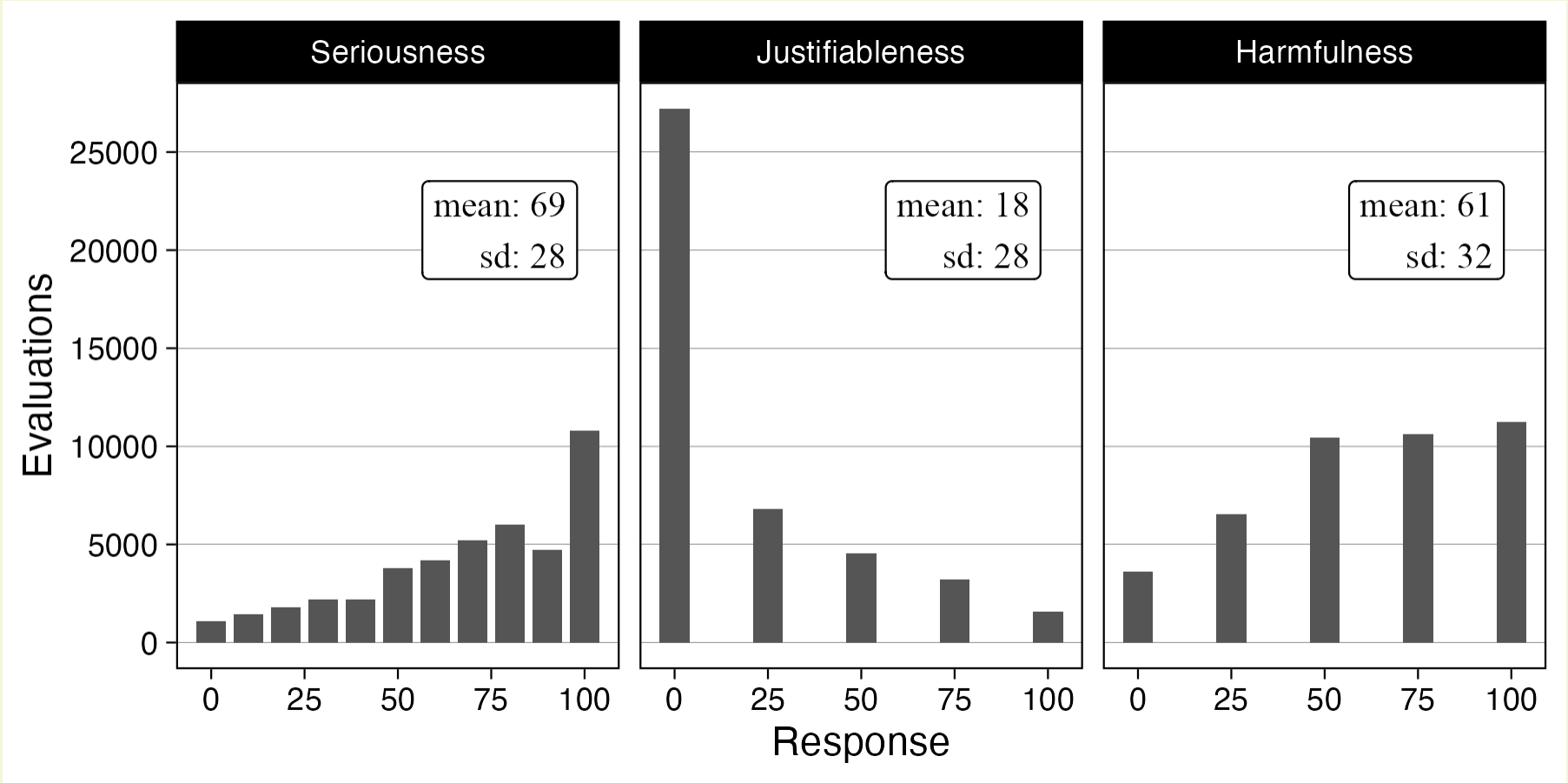
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☐ Ved ikke

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Treatment example (1 out of 5) in Danish

# Story evaluations

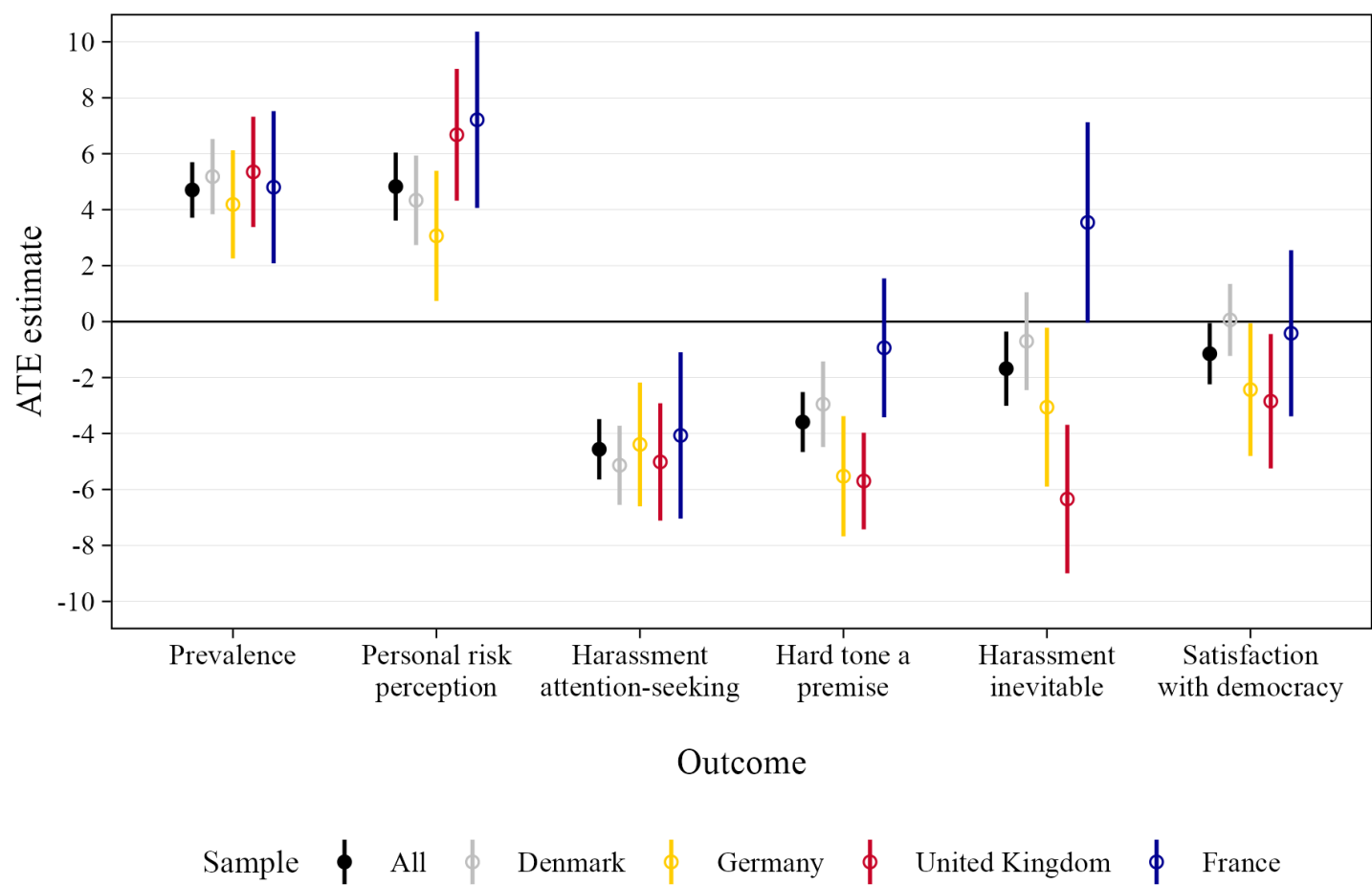


Evaluations of 43,460 harassmet stories

# Results

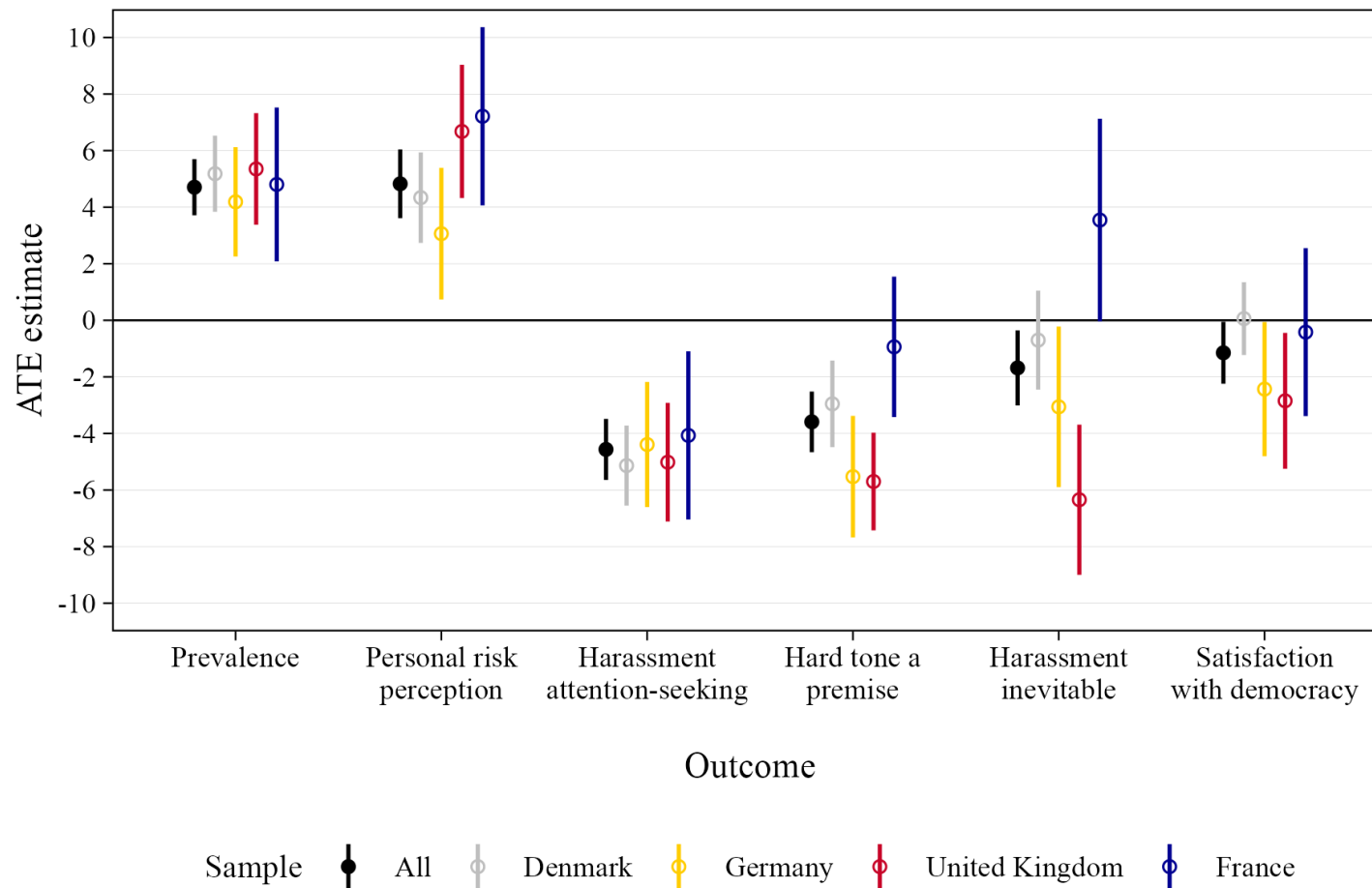


# Effects of raising awareness on harassment attitudes



- 4.7 %-points *increase* in perceived **prevalence**
- 4.8 %-points *increase* in personal **risk perception**

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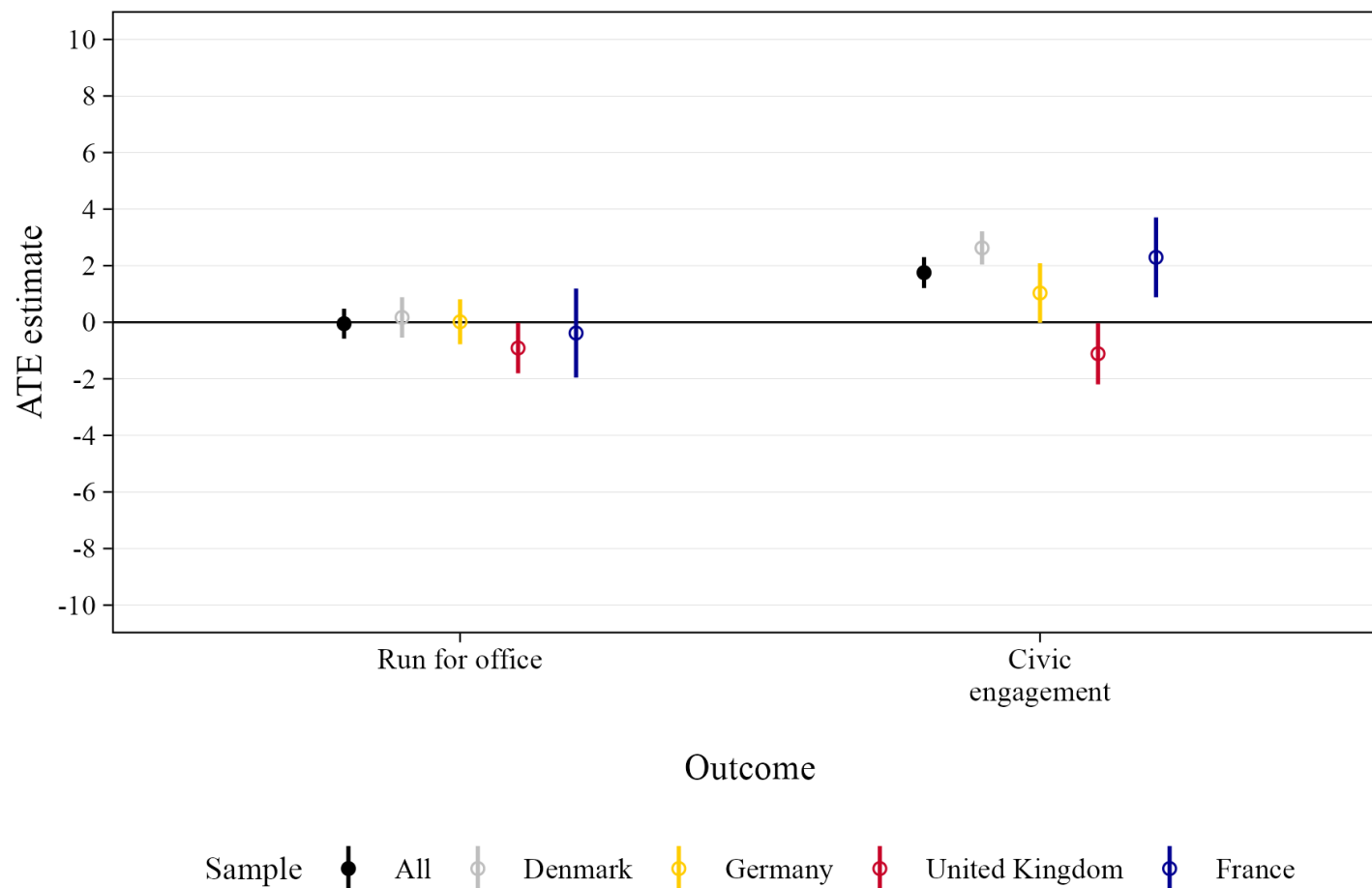
- 4.6 %-point *decrease* in belief that politicians' harassment stories are **about getting attention**
- 3.6 %-point *decrease* in belief that politicians **should have known about hard tone**
- 1.7 %-point *decrease* in belief that **harassment is inevitable** ( $p = 0.013$ )
- 1.1 %-point *decrease* in general **satisfaction with democracy** ( $p = 0.040$ )

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*Main hypothesis: People become **politically disengaged** and less likely to run for office when they hear stories about harassment against politicians*

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- No average decline in willingness to **run for office** ( $p = 0.851$ )
- No decline in **civic engagement**
- Instead, 1.8 %-points *increase* in **participation in six political activities** (e.g., contact politician, protest, petition, SoMe post)

# Deeper dive on run for office (RFO) outcome

- Some citizens are more likely than others to consider a political career
- We create additive **index** of (1) political interest, (2) partisanship, (3) internal efficacy, and (4) external efficacy
  - we also measure **pre-treatment** willingness to RFO
- We find statistically significant negative **interaction** with treatment (CATEs ... ↓):
  - 2.0 %-points RFO *decrease* for ~1/6 **highest index values**
  - 3.9 %-points RFO *decrease* for ~1/6 **highest reported pre-tests**
  - (No conditional effects for groups with **lower likelihood of running**)
- In sum, evidence that *the most likely future candidates* are in fact **scared away**
  - arguably still modest effect

# Conclusions

- What are the effects of raising awareness about politicians' real harassment experiences?
- Across four European democracies, it causes:
  - higher acknowledgement of harassment
  - lower acceptance
  - more civic engagement
  - good, but ...
- Citizens are also potential candidates of the future. Does it affect their **willingness to run for office**?
  - on average, **no** (arguably good)
  - but clear indications that **it does** for the more **likely candidates**
  - however, fairly modest (conditional) **effect size**: ~2-4 %-points

Thank you

